

1.2.4.1 Building an organised attack

There are three stages involved in building an organised attack, namely opening up, build-up play and finishing on goal.

Opening up: the transition from defence to attack, which involves the execution of initial tactical elements and movements, and is performed as soon as the team regains possession of the ball.

Build-up: coordinated movement with and without the ball that is designed to break up the opposition's defensive system and help the team develop play. Possession of the ball and defensive balance are maintained at all times, with the aim of creating advantageous situations and numerical or positional advantages which allow play to move forward into the final phase of the attack so that an opportunity to finish on goal may be created.

Finishing on goal: the final phase, in which the attacking team attempts to make the most of the advantageous situations that have been created via opening up and building up play, and, ultimately, to finish the move with a shot on goal.

As a rule, the following points need to be taken into account:

- The build-up phase is not always needed.
- An attack can be built using a pre-planned and systematic strategy, with the team following clear instructions. Alternatively, players can be given the creative freedom to make attacking decisions on the basis of their reading of the game.
- The structured use of tactical systems and rotations is common, and provides a positional and dynamic base from which to create play, as well as solutions for finishing on goal.
- In all of these phases, it is important to take into account the amount of space available.
- Attacking movement must be balanced with the idea of maintaining organised and logical positions at all times.

To build an attack correctly, various attacking models are needed, as is the use of several different technical/tactical options:

- In order to help one's team maintain possession it is essential to provide constant **support** to the player on the ball.
- **Off-the-ball movement** is a basic core concept, in which players without possession move off the ball in order to lose their marker and find space so that they can try and break down the opposition's defensive system.
- Making territorial advances in the game largely relies on concepts such as the **depth** and **width** of players' positioning on the court.
- **Movement off the ball** combined with a good reading of the game can create passing opportunities for the player in possession. Similarly, one of the objectives of movement off the ball is to **create/occupy/use space**.
- Another fundamental aspect is the ability to **keep the ball moving**.
- The intelligent and accurate use of the **basic core technical concepts**.
- **To draw out opposition defenders** it is important that players adopt a **body position** that demonstrates a tactical intent to push forward.

1.2.4.2 Positional attack

The positional attack is the formation and manoeuvre utilised by a team that has to attack an organised defence.

We have already seen that there are three stages in building an attack, but a positional attack involves only two of these: 'the build-up' and 'finishing on goal'.

For this reason, in a positional attack, it becomes necessary to deploy one of several specific systems. The most common systems are **3-1, 4-0 and 2-2, as well as specific systems for situations when outnumbering the opposition (5v4 and 4v3)**.

1.2.4.3 Attacking transition

The attacking transition is the switch from defence to attack when possession has been recovered, and corresponds to three phases: opening up, the counter-attack and the quick attack.

As an offensive process, the attacking transition also involves three phases of development (opening-up, build-up and finishing on goal). It is important to note that attacks take place in a short space of time and do not always involve all three phases.

1.2.5 Defensive tactics

Defensive tactics are those individual or group elements that players execute when their team is not in possession, to counteract or have some kind of impact on their opponents for the purpose of achieving their defensive objectives.

As can be seen in the transition from attack to defence, when possession has been lost, there are four phases, the first two of which form the defensive transition.

Phases of defence



Balance: the position that the attacking players need to adopt at the moment when possession is lost in order to give their team balance and prevent the opposition from catching them out via an attacking transition.

Buying time: an action performed by any player on an opponent who is in possession, with the aim of slowing the game down to allow the defence to drop back and reorganise.

Dropping back: the action of getting back as quickly as possible, either behind the ball or into an area which allows the team to regroup and organise their defence.

Defensive organisation: the actions executed and positions adopted by players after dropping back, so that they can organise and form a balanced and disciplined positional defence, in line with a specific tactical plan and shape.

Positional defence: the defensive actions that are executed once all defenders are organised and in position.

1.2.5.1 Building an organised defence

Building an organised defence is primarily based on the last two phases: defensive organisation and positional defence (also known as the 'systemised defence'). Other fundamental aspects to consider when building the defence are an awareness of the game space and how high up the court the defensive lines are. The defending team can adopt a high pressing defence, a three-quarter court open defence or a closed defence (behind the halfway line).

The types of defence available are:

- **Man-marking system:** a type of defence in which each player has an individual responsibility, and is required to mark one of the opposition's players.
- **Zonal system:** a type of defence in which the players are not responsible for marking a specific player, but rather for defending a designated area or zone of the court. Each defender is responsible for dealing with the opposing players who move into their zone.
- **Mixed system:** a type of defence which combines individual and zonal systems, where one or more players man-mark and the rest defend a zone.
- **Switching defence:** a man-marking system in which defenders switch opponents in line with the guidelines/instructions given to the group as a whole. A switching defence can combine positive aspects from both man-marking and zonal systems, but it relies on core defensive technical/tactical concepts being properly implemented and on sound decision-making.